MEMO (DRAFT TEMPLATE, placeholder text only)

Hard limits: 1,000 words maximum (body text; confirm with the instructor whether exhibit captions and the header count, and stay under to be safe). Up to 3 exhibits (figures or tables). General policy audience: no jargon, no equations, define any technical term in a clause. The technical appendix has no word limit and is where the methods go.

TO: Governor-elect, State of Rhode Island
FROM: [Your name], Policy Analyst
DATE: November 9, 2026
RE: Lifting the charter moratorium and doubling the cap from 28 to 56

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1. Bottom line (target: ~100 words)

[Placeholder: 2-3 sentences stating the net assessment up front, e.g. "Lifting the moratorium is likely to [raise / not change / lower] statewide proficiency by [small/uncertain amount], with effects concentrated in [Providence / urban core]. The result depends mainly on [which kind of charters expand]." State confidence level and the one or two things the conclusion hinges on. Neutral analyst voice: no advocacy.]

2. What the proposal does and what we know (target: ~120 words)

[Placeholder: Brief context: June 2026 law, pause through 2028-29, cap cut from 35 to 28, proposal to double to 56. Current charter enrollment share and number of charters (cite RIDE). One sentence on why raw charter-vs-district comparisons mislead (families choose to apply), and that this memo relies on designs that deal with that problem.]

3. Overall proficiency (target: ~170 words) ← Exhibit 1

[Placeholder: What credible evidence says about charter effects on test scores (lottery-based studies, matched-student studies), and what that implies for RI. Give an estimated effect size in plain terms (e.g. "equivalent to X extra days of learning"), with a range. Note that new charters may differ from existing ones, and that the effect on statewide proficiency is diluted by the share of students enrolled. Include a rough scenario: if charter share rises from X% to Y%, statewide proficiency changes by about Z points.]

4. Inequality (target: ~170 words) ← Exhibit 2

[Placeholder: Proficiency gaps by low-income status, race/ethnicity, and special-education status, charter vs. district. Who enrolls (and who leaves) in RI charters. Whether evidence suggests larger gains for low-income or Black and Hispanic students in urban settings. Flag special-education and English-learner enrollment and attrition differences. State whether expansion would likely narrow or widen gaps.]

5. Geography (target: ~170 words) ← Exhibit 3

[Placeholder: Where charters are now and where new ones are likely (Providence, Central Falls, Pawtucket, Woonsocket, Newport, etc.). District-level effects: enrollment loss, per-pupil funding

impact, stranded fixed costs, and who pays under the state funding formula. Suburban and rural districts: little direct effect, possible fiscal side effects. Frame by legislators' districts.]

6. Other constituencies (target: ~120 words)

[Placeholder: Teachers (unionization rates, pay, turnover, certification differences, district layoffs vs. new charter hiring), district taxpayers and municipal budgets, families on waitlists, existing charter operators. Keep to 2-3 groups with one concrete fact each.]

7. Risks, uncertainty and recommendation (target: ~150 words)

[Placeholder: Main uncertainties (effects of new vs. established charters, data limits, fiscal assumptions). Neutral options if useful, e.g. doubling the cap but conditioning approvals on performance, location, or student-mix criteria; phasing; funding-formula adjustments. Close with what would change the assessment.]

Word budget check: 100 + 120 + 170 + 170 + 170 + 120 + 150 = 1,000. Trim each section by about 5-10% to leave slack for the header and captions.

EXHIBIT PLAN (max 3)

Exhibit 1: Proficiency (Overall proficiency section) Bar or dot plot of RI proficiency (ELA and math) for charter vs. district students, raw, next to the causal estimates from the literature, so readers see the gap between raw differences and effects. Alternative: a scenario chart showing statewide proficiency change at different charter shares.

Data: RIDE Data Portal / report cards (RICAS results by school); Stanford SEDA for growth measures.

Exhibit 2: Inequality (Inequality section) Small multiples or a table: proficiency by subgroup (low-income, Black, Hispanic, white, students with disabilities, English learners), charter vs. district, plus enrollment share of each subgroup in charters vs. their host districts.

Data: RIDE Data Portal enrollment and assessment by subgroup; Urban Institute Education Data Explorer (CCD) for enrollment demographics.

Exhibit 3: Geography (Geography section) Map or ranked bar chart by district: current charter enrollment share, district enrollment trend, and estimated per-pupil funding at stake. Highlight the districts where expansion is most likely.

Data: RIDE enrollment and finance data; district shapefiles (Census TIGER) if mapping.

EVIDENCE TO LOOK FOR (all must be verified before citing; I have not confirmed any of these)

Candidate studies to locate and read (check each exists, and that the findings match what you write):

- **CREDO (Stanford)** national charter school studies (2013 and 2023 editions) and any RI-specific or Northeast report: matched-student comparisons.
- **Abdulkadiroglu, Angrist, Dynarski, Kane, Pathak (2011), Quarterly Journal of Economics**: Boston charter lotteries.
- **Angrist, Pathak, Walters (2013), AEJ: Applied**: why urban charters outperform non-urban ones.
- **Cohodes, Setren, Walters**: replication of successful Boston charter models (expansion question, directly relevant to "doubling").
- **Dobbie and Fryer**: Harlem Children's Zone and Promise Academy.
- Research on **fiscal effects on districts** and **competitive effects on district schools** (e.g. Cohodes and Parham review; Ridley and Terrier on fiscal externalities).
- Research on **teachers in charters** (turnover, pay, unionization).
- RI-specific: RIDE reports, Rhode Island Kids Count, local think tank or press analyses on funding formula impacts (treat as secondary and check claims against RIDE data).

Key methodological point for the memo and appendix: lottery (oversubscribed admissions) studies give the cleanest effect of attending a charter versus not; matched-student and value-added studies are weaker; raw proficiency gaps reflect selection. Be explicit about which evidence you lean on and why, and about whether lottery results (from over-subscribed, mostly urban schools) generalize to doubling the cap.

Own-analysis ideas (state-level, observational):

1. School-level charter vs. district-comparison proficiency, with controls for demographics (descriptive, not causal).
2. Growth or cohort-based measures from SEDA, which are less distorted by starting point than proficiency levels.
3. District-level exposure: charter share of enrollment vs. district enrollment change and per-pupil spending.
4. Scenario arithmetic: effect size $\times$ students shifted $\times$ baseline = statewide change (with ranges).

CHECKLIST BEFORE SUBMISSION

- ☐ Body is at most 1,000 words
- ☐ No more than 3 exhibits, each referenced in the text and self-explanatory
- ☐ All four required topics covered: proficiency, inequality, geography, other constituencies
- ☐ Neutral tone, since the side assignment comes later
- ☐ Every citation verified (source exists, claim matches)
- ☐ Every number in the memo traceable to code in the zipped folder
- ☐ Appendix and code README written; no API keys in the folder
- ☐ Upload: memo, appendix (PDF or Word), zipped code folder